

Wooden Churches of Kizhi

A pair of multidomed churches and a bell tower constructed entirely of wood in traditional Russian style



On a spit of land on the island of Kizhi, in Lake Onega, northwest Russia, is the site of two remarkable 18th-century churches, the Church of the Transfiguration and the Church of the Intercession, together with a 19th-century bell tower. The three buildings are constructed entirely of wood: the walls are built from logs of Scots pine, the roofs are made of spruce planks and shingles, and the domes are covered with shingles of aspen—weathering has made them appear silvery. It is the distinctive use of multiple onion domes that makes the Kizhi churches unique. Unlike other traditional Russian wooden churches with a simple pyramidal roof, the octagonal Church of the Transfiguration features 22 cupolas with decorative shingles.

▽ TRADITIONAL TIMBER CONSTRUCTION

The Church of the Transfiguration (center), along with the Church of the Intercession (left) and the Belfry (right) behind it, are masterpieces of Russian joinery. They were built using only basic tools, such as axes and chisels.

BUILDING WITH WOOD

The churches were constructed using traditional Russian carpentry techniques—the horizontal logs of the walls were fitted together with interlocking or dovetail joints. The only nails used in the construction were for securing the wooden roof tiles that were layered together to form the onion domes.

